one-fifth of its ancient peak, and most of the country -- though named by historians of the ancient world, the eastern horn of the Semitic "fertile crescent" -- has now reverted to the desert. It is no wonder that in Semitic mythology the magician is the man who can divine water, and the great magician is the one that can strike water from the rock.

On the eastern border of historic Palestine, the line of the desert is indicated fairly accurately by the Pilgrim Railroad, which ran from Damascus through Amman and Maan to Medina. At many points, the desert begins a few miles to the west of the railroad line. Measuring from the great rift in which lie the Jordan, the Dead Sea, and the Wadi Araba, the desert is commonly less than 30 miles to the east and rarely as much as 40 miles. Never, along the eastern march of historic Palestine, is the desert more than 100 miles from the Mediterranean.

Even within this boundary there are large sami-desert areas (with an average annual rainfall of less than 5 inches), such as the Negeb of Palestine. Enthusiasm and archeological error have attributed to the Negeb a history of abundant population, which modern hydrological engineering may give it in the future but which it has never yet supported. Judicious scholars, such as Albright, have concluded that the famed cities of the Negeb flourished at different times during a period of nearly 1,000 years. There were never more than one or two large towns at the same time, and these towns lived partly from the caravan trade. The desert was beaten back by ceaseless effort. Almost every house was equipped with cisterns. Reservoirs and dams were built wherever possible, to make the most of the meager rainfall. Wells were dug to tap the underground waters. In its most flourishing period, the Negeb may have supported a settled population of several tens of thousands of people.

The ancient Semitic homeland extends from the southern shore of the Arabian peninsula to the northern limit of the "fertile crescent" in Mesopotamia and Syria. Everywhere in this area the nomadic herdsman, who pastures his flocks in lands too arid to support agriculture, is a near neighbor. The annual nomadic cycle brings the desert herdsman into periodic contact with the settler. But the